The rabbis were told to expect a warm welcome from the committee leadership—but insults from some of the other Knesset members.

Around the same time, the Israeli government held a secret conference in Jerusalem to discuss the boycott movement.[1] One of the attendees was Frank Luntz, the American political operative who helped develop Newt Gingrich's "Contract with America". Luntz is a wordsmith, a consultant who tests individual phrases on hundreds of focus groups, searching for language that provokes the right emotional response from voters. Thus oil drilling (negative, dirty) became "energy exploration" (positive, evokes a frontier spirit); the estate tax became the "death tax". In a 2007 interview with NPR he even redefined the word "Orwellian": it was a positive concept, he explained, "to speak with absolute clarity, to be succinct", an interpretation that surely sent the author spinning in his grave.[2]

While he does not work for the Israeli government, Luntz has often used his focus groups to test pro-Israel messaging, usually with the goal of selling the Western world on right-wing Israeli policies. He drafted a handbook in 2009 that explained, among other things, how to justify the steady expansion of settlements in the occupied territories. *Newsweek* summarized his findings: "Be positive. Turn the issue away from settlements and toward peace. Invoke ethnic cleansing."[3] (Netanyahu sometimes seems to follow his advice, not least in a much-maligned 2016 YouTube video that cast the Palestinian refusal to accept settlers in their future state as a sort of modern-day *Judenrein*.)

In recent years, though, his focus groups have demonstrated a steady decline in American support for Israel. Luntz sounded an alarm bell in 2015 after he surveyed "opinion elites"—highly-educated, high-earning, politically active members of the establishment. Three-quarters of the Democrats thought Israel had too much influence over US foreign policy. From the same sample, 47 per cent described it as a racist country. An overwhelming majority thought settlements were an "impediment to peace", despite his rebranding efforts. "Israel can no longer claim to have the bipartisan support of America," Luntz said.[4]

The attendees at the closed Jerusalem conference heard a similar warning. Luntz had done a survey of Jewish students in the US, asking if they believed that Israel wanted peace, and if they viewed it as a "civilized and Western country". Most did not. Perhaps most striking, only 31 per cent agreed that Israel was a true democracy. "The ministry of tourism came out